missions to destroy any trade travelling between the plains and the ports of Gujarat.

It was a resistance that continued to the very end of the rana's life, and one that Akbar never stopped trying to break – and yet, if there was a personal rivalry between Rana Pratap and his foe, one could argue that it was not so much with Akbar, whom the rana never met, but with Akbar's young Rajput general, Man Singh.

In the spring of 1573, some three years before Haldighati and only weeks after Man Singh stopped Akbar from stabbing himself in the stomach, the emperor had sent the young Rajput prince to try and extract submission from Mewar. Man Singh was back in Fatehpur by the summer, having met the rana but with little success. Again, in September, after the great battle for Ahmedabad, Akbar sent Bhagwant Das, Man Singh's father, to Mewar. Bhagwant Das returned within the month, writes Abul Fazl, bringing the rana's young son, Amar Singh, as guarantor of his father's fealty, along with a flattering message: for now, the rana 'presented his petition through the Rajah [Bhagwant Das] . . . But [w]hen his desolate heart should become soothed by the lapse of time, he too would come and do homage in person.'

Abul Fazl's dry narration – of diplomatic missions making their slow progress – are a far cry from the tales of unbending pride that fill the histories of Mewar as James Tod tells them.[32] This, then, is how Tod relates the encounter between the Rajputs of Mewar and those of Amber.

Man Singh did, indeed, arrive at Rana Pratap's door, but the rana would not eat with him. He sent little Amar Singh instead, and when Man Singh protested, he sent cold regrets, saying that 'he could not eat with a Rajput who gave his sister to a Turk, and who probably ate with him'.[33]

Raja Man Singh, no less proud than his host, got up from his meal and on to his horse. Rana Pratap came out, it seems, as Man Singh was about to leave. The prince of Amber turned to the rana of Mewar and declared, 'If I do not humble your pride, my name is not Man.'

Man Singh would have been in his very early twenties; Rana Pratap was ten-odd years his senior, and amused, perhaps, by the challenge. The rana replied that 'he should always be happy to meet him' – and a less restrained voice from among the chiefs of Mewar called out that Man Singh should